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Postal Manual Vol VII

(Railway Mail Service)

DISCLAIMER: *This booklet has been prepared strictly from an examination point of view. While every effort has been made to ensure accuracy and the inclusion of recent changes, amendments, and updates to the relevant Acts, Rules, and Regulations, this document is intended as a study aid only. Readers and students are strongly recommended to refer to official government sources or gazettes for the most reliable and authoritative information.*

Postal Manual Volume VII : Railway Mail Service

Chapter 1: General Rules

Rule 1. The Railway Mail Service

The Railway Mail Service (R.M.S.) is responsible for the carriage of mails by rail, road, and river, and for the collection and distribution of mails received from Post Offices and mail offices, and their sorting during transit.

Note: The Service is administered by **Heads of Circles**, assisted by **Postmasters General** and **Directors of Postal Services**, and is organized into Divisions under the control of **Superintendents of R.M.S.**

Rule 2. Sorting Mail Office

A Sorting Mail Office is a stationary office of the Railway Mail Service, where mails are sorted.

- (a) It deals with the contents of mail bags addressed to it and with closed bags sent to it for disposal.
- (b) It closes bags for other offices and sections.
- (c) It may be located at a Railway Station or in a town.

Rule 3. Transit Section

A Transit Section is a traveling office of the Railway Mail Service working on a railway or river steamer line.

- (a) It deals with the contents of mail bags addressed to it.
- (b) It closes bags for other offices and sections.
- (c) It is in charge of a Sorting Assistant or a Mail Guard.

Rule 4. Mail Office

A Mail Office is a stationary office of the Railway Mail Service which deals with closed bags only.

- (a) It does not open or sort the contents of mail bags (except in special cases authorized by the **Head of the Circle**).
- (b) It exchanges mails with sections and other mail offices.
- (c) It is usually located at a Railway Station.

Rule 5. Record Office

A Record Office is a stationary office of the Railway Mail Service where the work papers of the sections and mail offices attached to it are prepared, checked, and placed on record.

- (a) It is also the stock depot for the supply of forms, bags, and stationery to the sections and offices attached to it.
- (b) It is in charge of a **Head Record Officer** or a **Sub-Record Officer**.

Rule 6. Head Record Office

A Head Record Office (H.R.O.) is a Record Office situated at the headquarters of a Superintendent of R.M.S., or at a station where there is a large concentration of R.M.S. staff.

- It is in charge of a **Head Record Officer**.

Rule 7. Sub-Record Office

A Sub-Record Office (S.R.O.) is a Record Office situated at a station other than the headquarters of the Superintendent.

- It is in charge of a **Sub-Record Officer**.

Rule 8. Bag Office

A Bag Office is an office (usually a Record Office) which is responsible for the accounting and distribution of mail bags.

🔔 **STATUTORY NOTE:** The classification of Bag Offices (Unit, District, Circle, and Central Bag Offices) is detailed in the **Postal Manual Volume V (Appendices)**, but their operational duties within the R.M.S. are governed by this Manual.

Rule 9. Sorting Assistant

A Sorting Assistant is an official of the Railway Mail Service whose duties are:

- (a) To sort letters and parcels.
- (b) To close and open mail bags.
- (c) To assist the **Head Sorting Assistant** in the work of the set.

Note: The term "Sorter" appearing in older versions of this Act is to be read as "**Sorting Assistant**" vide Directorate instructions.

Rule 10. Mail Guard

A Mail Guard is an official of the Railway Mail Service whose duties are:

- (a) To take charge of mails in a Transit Section or Mail Office.
- (b) To exchange mails with sections and offices.¹
- (c) To assist the Sorting Assistant in the handling of heavy mails.

Rule 11. Van

The term "Van" implies the compartment of a railway carriage or steamer assigned for the use of a Transit Section.

Rule 12. Trip

A journey performed by a set of a section from one station to another is called a "Trip".

- (a) **Out-Trip:** The trip from the headquarters of the section towards the out-station.
- (b) **In-Trip:** The trip from the out-station towards the headquarters.

Rule 13. Set

A Set is a group of officials (Sorting Assistants, Mail Guards, and Van Peons) working together in a section or office.

- Sets are numbered serially (e.g., **Set No. 1, Set No. 2**).
- The working hours and strength of a set are fixed by the **Superintendent**.²

Rule 14. Beat

The portion of a railway or steamer line over which a section works is called its "Beat".

Rule 15. Camp Correspondence

Camp Correspondence refers to letters and other articles addressed to high officers of Government (e.g., the President, Prime Minister) and other high dignitaries while on tour.

- These are enclosed in special bags known as "**Camp Bags**" or "**Special Bags**".
- They are dealt with in accordance with the special instructions issued by the **Director General**.

Rule 16. Late Letters

Late Letters are letters presented at a post office or mail office, or posted in a train letter-box, after the prescribed hour for closing the mail but within the interval allowed for posting with a late fee.

- (a) Such letters must bear the **late fee** in addition to the ordinary postage.
- (b) If the late fee is not prepaid, the letter is treated as unpaid or insufficiently paid.

Rule 17. Too Late Letters

"Too Late" letters are those posted within such an interval before the dispatch of the mail that they cannot be included in that dispatch.

- These are stamped "**Too Late**" and detained for the next dispatch.

Rule 18. Mis-sent and Mis-directed Articles

- **Mis-sent Article:** An article which has been erroneously routed to an office or section to which it should not have been sent.
- **Mis-directed Article:** An article on which the incorrect destination has been written in English by the office of posting.

Chapter 2: Organization of the Service

Rule 19. Control

The Railway Mail Service in a Circle is under the control of the Head of the Circle. The Service within a Circle is formed into one or more Divisions, and the Divisions are subdivided into Sub-Divisions.

Rule 20. Divisions

A Division is under the control of a Superintendent, Railway Mail Service.

- (a) The Superintendent is responsible for the general administration and efficiency of the Service within his Division.
- (b) He is assisted by one or more **Assistant Superintendents** and **Inspectors**.

Rule 21. Sub-Divisions

A Sub-Division is under the charge of an Assistant Superintendent or Inspector, Railway Mail Service.

- (a) The jurisdiction of a Sub-Division is fixed by the **Head of the Circle**.
- (b) The Inspector is responsible for the supervision of the work of the sections and offices in his Sub-Division and for the investigation of complaints and irregularities.

Rule 22. Grouping of Sections and Offices

For the purposes of administration and control, every Transit Section and Mail Office is attached to a Record Office.

- (a) The Record Office serves as the stationary office for the sections attached to it.
- (b) The staff of the sections and the work papers connected with their trips are managed by the Record Office.

Rule 23. Naming of Sections

Transit Sections are designated by letters of the alphabet or by numbers, or by the names of the railway lines on which they work.

- (a) When a section works in two or more portions, these are distinguished by the addition of suffix letters (e.g., **Section A-1, Section A-2**).
- (b) The designation is fixed by the **Director General**.

Rule 24. Numbering of Trips

The trips of a section are numbered serially to correspond with the numbers of the trains or steamers by which the trips are performed.

- (a) When a section performs more than one trip by the same train (in different portions of the line), the trips are distinguished by the addition of suffixes (e.g., **Trip 1, Trip 2**).

Rule 25. Numbering of Sets

The sets of a section or office are numbered serially, beginning with No. 1.

- The number of sets is determined by the number of working hours per week and the length of the trips.

Rule 26. Working Hours

The working hours of the staff of the Railway Mail Service are regulated by the Head of the Circle in accordance with the standards prescribed by the Director General.

 **STATUTORY UPDATE (2025):** The standard working hours for RMS operative staff are generally fixed at **48 hours** per week for stationary duty and **30 to 36 hours** per week for traveling duty, subject to overtime allowances as per current 7th CPC recommendations.

Rule 27. Weekly Working Hours

- (1) The period of duty for a set of a Transit Section is so arranged that the weekly working hours do not exceed the prescribed limit.
- (2) In calculating the working hours, credit is given for the time spent in attending the Record Office and for the time spent at the platform before the departure and after the arrival of the train.

Rule 28. Rest

The staff of a Transit Section are entitled to rest periods between trips.

- (a) The duration of rest is fixed by the **Superintendent** with the approval of the **Head of the Circle**.
- (b) Rest Houses are provided at out-stations for the use of the staff.

Rule 29. Classification of Mail Offices

Mail Offices are classified as:

- (a) **Sorting Mail Offices:** Where sorting of letters and parcels is performed.
- (b) **Transit Mail Offices (TMO):** Where only closed bags are handled.
- (c) **Record Offices:** As defined in Rule 5.

Rule 30. Sorting Patterns

The sorting work of a Mail Office or Section is regulated by a Sorting List or Sorting Memo issued by the Superintendent.

- (a) The Sorting List details the manner in which articles for different destinations are to be disposed of.
 - (b) Changes in sorting patterns must be authorized by the **Superintendent**.
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Chapter 3: Duties of Officers

Rule 31. Superintendent

The Superintendent is the administrative head of the Division.

- (1) He is the appointing authority for the cadre of **Mail Guards** and **Multi-Tasking Staff (MTS)** within his jurisdiction.
- (2) He is responsible for the correct maintenance of the Stock Registers and the verification of stock.
- (3) He must inspect the Record Offices, Mail Offices, and Sections in his Division as per the schedule prescribed by the **Head of the Circle**.

Rule 32. Inspector

The Inspector is the executive officer in charge of a Sub-Division.

- (1) He must travel frequently within his jurisdiction to supervise the working of sections and offices.
 - (2) He must verify the bag balances and the stock of stamps and stationery.
 - (3) He must inquire into all cases of loss, fraud, or abstraction of mails.
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Rule 33. Head Record Officer

The Head Record Officer is in charge of a Head Record Office.

- (1) He is responsible for the preparation of the pay bills and contingent bills for the staff attached to his office.
- (2) He distributes the forms, bags, and stationery to the Sub-Record Offices and sections.
- (3) He checks the **Daily Reports** and **Mail Abstracts** received from the sections.

Rule 34. Sub-Record Officer

The Sub-Record Officer performs duties similar to the Head Record Officer but on a smaller scale, for the sections and offices attached to his Sub-Record Office.

- He is responsible for the safe custody of the cash and stamps supplied to him.

Rule 35. Head Sorting Assistant

The Head Sorting Assistant is the official in charge of a set of a Section or Mail Office.

- (1) He is responsible for the discipline and work of the set.
- (2) He personally closes and seals the **Registered Bag** and the **Insurance Bag** (wherever applicable).
- (3) He maintains the **Mail Abstract** and the **Work Papers**.

Rule 36. Duties of Sorting Assistant

A Sorting Assistant must:

- (1) Attend the Record Office or Mail Office at the prescribed hour.
- (2) Sort the mails strictly according to the **Sorting List**.
- (3) Examines the bags to ensure they are in good condition and the seals are intact.

- (4) Obey the orders of the **Head Sorting Assistant**.

Rule 37. Duties of Mail Guard

A Mail Guard must:

- (1) Receive and exchange mail bags.
- (2) Ensure the safety of the mails in the van or office.
- (3) Assist the Sorting Assistant in tying bundles and labeling bags.
- (4) In the absence of a Sorting Assistant, he may be required to perform simple sorting duties.

Rule 38. Custody of Metal Tokens

Every official entering a Mail Van or Mail Office must carry a Metal Token (or Identity Card) as an authority for his presence.

- (1) The tokens are supplied by the Record Officer.
- (2) They must be produced on demand by any Inspecting Officer or Railway Authority.

🔔 **STATUTORY UPDATE (2025):** The use of copper/brass tokens has largely been replaced by **Biometric ID Cards** or **Departmental Identity Cards** with holograms, but the statutory rule regarding "Authorized Access" remains in force.

Rule 39. Camp Articles

Special care must be taken in the handling of Camp Articles.

- (1) They must be kept separate from ordinary mails.
- (2) They must be delivered immediately upon arrival.

Rule 40. Accidents

In the event of a railway accident or fire involving a Mail Van:

- (1) The **Head Sorting Assistant** or **Mail Guard** must first endeavor to save the mails and the lives of the staff.
 - (2) He must immediately send a report by telegram (now phone/email) to the **Superintendent** and the **Inspector**.
 - (3) He must remain with the saved mails until relieved by a responsible officer.
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Chapter 4: Work Papers and Mail Exchange

Rule 41. Work Papers

The term "Work Papers" includes all the documents, lists, and abstracts which are required to be prepared by a section or office in connection with its work.

- (1) The Work Papers must be prepared in the prescribed forms.
- (2) They must be neatly written and signed by the responsible officers.
- (3) They are preserved in the **Record Office** for a period of **18 months**, after which they are sold as waste paper, unless required for any specific enquiry.

Rule 42. Mail Abstract

The Mail Abstract is a record of the number of bags received and dispatched by a section or office.

- (1) It is divided into two parts: **Receipts** and **Dispatches**.
 - (2) It must show the number of bags of each description (e.g., Letter Bags, Parcel Bags, Packet Bags) exchanged with every office and section on the beat.
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- (3) The totals of the bags received must be compared with the totals of the bags dispatched to ensure correctness.
- (4) It is maintained by the **Head Sorting Assistant** or **Mail Guard**.

 **STATUTORY UPDATE (2025):** In computerized Transit Mail Offices (C-TMOs) and offices migrated to **CSI (Core System Integrator)**, the manual Mail Abstract is replaced by the system-generated "**Bag Manifest**" or "**Mail List**". However, manual abstracts are still mandatory for Transit Sections (Train/Road) where handheld devices are not yet fully operational.

Rule 43. Due Mail List

The Due Mail List is a document showing the details of the bags to be received and dispatched by a section or office.

- (1) It shows the names of the offices/sections from which bags are due to be received and to which bags are due to be dispatched.
- (2) It indicates the frequency of the exchange (e.g., Daily, Weekly).
- (3) It serves as a guide for the Sorting Assistant and Mail Guard in the exchange of mails.

Rule 44. The Carrier

The term "Carrier" refers to the railway train, steamer, motor vehicle, or runner by which the mails are conveyed.

Rule 45. Exchange of Mails

The exchange of mails between a section or office and a carrier must be carried out efficiently and safely.

- (1) The **Head Sorting Assistant** or **Mail Guard** must personally superintend the receipt and dispatch of mails.

- (2) He must ensure that the correct number of bags is received and dispatched as per the **Due Mail List**.
- (3) He must examine the seals and condition of the bags at the time of receipt.

Rule 46. Receipt of Bags

- (1) When receiving bags, the official must check them against the **Mail List** or **Invoice**.
- (2) If any bag is missing or if an extra bag is received, a remark must be made immediately in the **Mail Abstract** and the **Error Book**.
- (3) If a bag appears to have been tampered with, it must be opened in the presence of witnesses (if possible) and the contents checked.

Rule 47. Dispatch of Bags

- (1) Bags for dispatch must be properly labeled and sealed.
- (2) They must be handed over to the carrier against a proper receipt.
- (3) In the case of sections, the bags are handed over at the platform to the Mail Peon or the official of the stationary office.

Rule 48. Transit Bags

A Transit Bag is a bag used to enclose several small bags (e.g., account bags, station bundles) to secure their safety and facilitate handling.

- (1) It is addressed to a particular office or section.
- (2) It must be labeled with a **Symbol Label** (usually a "T" label).
- (3) It is opened by the receiving office, and the enclosed bags are taken out and disposed of.

Rule 49. Account Bag

An Account Bag is used between a Sub-Post Office and its Head Post Office (or between a Branch Office and its Account Office) to convey cash, account papers, and stamps.

- (1) It must contain an **Account Bag List**.
- (2) RMS officials are strictly prohibited from opening Account Bags unless authorized by the **Superintendent** in exceptional circumstances.

Rule 50. Sorting List

Every Sorting Mail Office and Section is supplied with a Sorting List.

- (1) It shows the manner in which articles for different post offices are to be disposed of (i.e., which bag they are to be sorted into).
- (2) The list is prepared by the **Superintendent** and must be kept up to date by the **Head Sorting Assistant**.

Rule 51. Station Bundle

A Station Bundle is a collection of unlabeled letters and other articles for a particular office, tied together and faced with a Check Slip.

- (1) It is prepared when the number of articles for a particular office exceeds **14**.
- (2) If the number is less than 14, the articles are sent loose in the bag or in a **Territorial Bundle**.

Rule 52. Territorial Bundle

A Territorial Bundle is a collection of articles for a particular State, District, or Territory, tied together and faced with a Check Slip.

- (1) It is prepared to facilitate sorting in the office of exchange.

- (2) It is labeled with the name of the Territory (e.g., "Madras Circle", "North Arcot District").

Rule 53. Labeling of Bundles

Every bundle of letters or other articles must be faced with a Check Slip.

- (1) The Check Slip must bear the name of the office of posting, the date stamp, and the signature of the Sorting Assistant who prepared the bundle.
- (2) This slip enables the responsibility for missending or misdirection to be fixed.

Rule 54. Check Slip

The Check Slip is a small piece of paper used to label bundles.

- (1) **Pink Slip:** For ordinary paid and unpaid bundles.
- (2) **Blue Slip:** For Air Mail bundles.
- (3) The Check Slip is an essential document for tracing errors.

Rule 55. Labeled Bundle

A Labeled Bundle implies a collection of articles tied together and distinguished by a label (Check Slip) to show its destination.

Rule 56. Express Bundles

Bundles containing Express Delivery articles (now largely superseded by Speed Post, but term remains in manual) must be distinguished by a special label or mark to ensure priority handling.

Rule 57. Facing

Facing is the arrangement of letters and other articles with the address side upwards and the addresses all turned in the same direction, to facilitate sorting and stamping.

Rule 58. Pre-sorting

Pre-sorting is the preliminary separation of mails into broad groups (e.g., "Local", "Mofussil", "Air Mail") before detailed sorting.

Rule 59. Beat Sort

Beat Sort refers to the sorting of mails according to the delivery beats of the postmen in the office of delivery.

- (Note: This is primarily a function of the Post Office, but RMS sections may perform beat sorts for specific large towns if ordered by the **Director General**).

Rule 60. Forward Bundle

A Forward Bundle consists of articles for offices beyond the beat of the section or office, which are sent to an intermediate office for further disposal.

Chapter 5: Registered and Insured Mails

Rule 61. Registered Abstract

The Registered Abstract is the account of registered articles and registered bags handled by a section or office.

- (1) It must be maintained by the **Head Sorting Assistant** or the **Registration Sorting Assistant**.
- (2) It shows the number of registered articles received and dispatched, detailing the office of origin and destination for each.
- (3) The abstract must be tallied at the end of the set's working hours to ensure that the number of articles received agrees with the number dispatched plus those detained (if any).

🔔 **STATUTORY UPDATE (2025):** In CSI-migrated offices and NSH (National Sorting Hubs), the manual Registered Abstract is replaced by the **Delivery Bill** and **Bag Manifest** generated by the system. However, the physical tallying of articles against the system list remains a mandatory duty.

Rule 62. Receipt of Registered Bags

- (1) Registered bags must be carefully examined at the time of receipt to ensure that the seals are intact and the bag is in good condition.
- (2) They must be weighed immediately upon receipt, and the weight recorded.
- (3) If there is any discrepancy in weight or condition, it must be noted in the **Error Book** and brought to the notice of the **Head Sorting Assistant**.

Rule 63. Opening of Registered Bags

- (1) Registered bags must be opened by the **Head Sorting Assistant** or the **Registration Sorting Assistant** in the presence of a witness (usually another Sorting Assistant).
- (2) The contents must be checked one by one against the **Registered List** enclosed in the bag.
- (3) If any article entered in the list is missing, or if an extra article is found, a note must be made on the list and in the **Error Book**, and the irregularity reported immediately.

Rule 64. Registered List

A Registered List is the invoice detailing the registered articles enclosed in a registered bag.

- (1) It must bear the date stamp of the dispatching office and the signature of the dispatching official.
- (2) It serves as the receipt for the articles when signed by the receiving official.

Rule 65. Sorting of Registered Articles

- (1) Registered articles must be sorted with the greatest care to ensure they are sent to the correct destination.
- (2) They must be kept separate from ordinary mails to prevent them from being mixed up or lost.
- (3) **Insured articles** must be separated from ordinary registered articles and handled as per specific rules for insurance.

Rule 66. Closing of Registered Bags

- (1) Registered bags must be closed and sealed by the **Head Sorting Assistant** or the **Registration Sorting Assistant** personally.
- (2) The **Registered List** must be placed inside the bag before closing.
- (3) The bag must be tied with a special knot and sealed with the **Insurance Seal** (if containing insured articles) or the **Registration Seal**.

Rule 67. Insured Bundles

- (1) When two or more insured articles are to be dispatched to the same office, they may be made up into an **Insured Bundle**.
- (2) The bundle must be wrapped in a registered list or paper, tied securely, and sealed.
- (3) The bundle is then treated as a single unit for the purpose of entry in the lists, but the individual articles must be detailed inside.

Rule 68. Check of Insured Articles

- (1) Every insured article must be carefully examined to see that it is properly packed and sealed in accordance with the rules.

- (2) The weight of the insured article must be checked against the weight noted on the article.
- (3) If the weight differs, or if there is any sign of tampering, the article must be detained and the matter reported.

Rule 69. Custody of Registered Articles

During the time registered articles are in a section or office, they must be kept in the personal custody of the Head Sorting Assistant or the Registration Sorting Assistant, usually in a locker or a secure bag.

Rule 70. Hand-to-Hand Exchange

Registered bags and articles must always be exchanged hand-to-hand between the relieving and relieved sets, or between the section/office and the carrier. They must never be left unattended.

Chapter 6: Miscellaneous Duties & Irregularities

Rule 71. Daily Report

The Daily Report is a crucial document submitted by the Head Sorting Assistant to the Superintendent through the Record Officer.

- (1) It contains a complete record of the trip or working hours of the set.
- (2) It must detail:
 - The punctuality of the train/steamer.
 - The receipt and dispatch of mails.
 - Any irregularities committed by the staff or observed in the mails received.
 - Complaints from the public or other offices.

- (3) It serves as the primary source of information for the Superintendent regarding the efficiency of the section.

Rule 72. Irregularities

Any breach of rules, loss of mail, damage to bags, or misconduct must be classified as an "Irregularity".

- (1) Irregularities are recorded in the **Error Book** and reported in the **Daily Report**.
- (2) They are categorized into **Major** and **Minor** irregularities depending on their gravity.

Rule 73. Error Book

The Error Book is a permanent record maintained in every section and mail office.

- (1) It contains entries of all errors and irregularities detected.
- (2) Each entry must be signed by the official in charge.
- (3) An extract of the Error Book must be submitted daily to the Superintendent.

Rule 74. Missending of Articles

- (1) If an article is missent to a section or office, it must be stamped "**Missent to...**" and forwarded to its correct destination by the first available dispatch.
- (2) The irregularity must be noted in the Error Book, specifying the office which committed the error.

Rule 75. Examination of Seals

- (1) The seals of all bags received must be examined to ensure they correspond with the office of dispatch and are not counterfeit.
- (2) If a seal is indistinct or differs from the standard, the bag must be opened with caution in the presence of witnesses.

Rule 76. Damage to Mails

- (1) If any article is found damaged in transit, a remark regarding its condition must be made on the article itself (e.g., "**Received in damaged condition**").
- (2) If the contents are exposed, they must be secured, and if necessary, enclosed in a fresh cover (Protective Cover).

Rule 77. Handling of Empty Bags

- (1) Empty bags must be returned promptly to the **District Bag Office** or the **Unit Bag Office**.
- (2) They must be tied in bundles and labeled as "**Empty Bags**".
- (3) Care must be taken to ensure no correspondence is left inside an empty bag (this is a serious irregularity known as "**Non-emptying of Bags**").

Rule 78. Preservation of Records

Records of the RMS are preserved for specific periods as prescribed by the Director General.

- (1) **Order Book:** Permanent.
- (2) **Daily Reports:** 18 months.
- (3) **Registered Abstracts:** 3 years (now 18 months in some contexts, refer to latest Manual Vol V Appendix).

🔔 **STATUTORY NOTE:** Always verify the preservation period with the latest **Appendix to Vol V** as digitization has reduced physical retention periods for some documents.

Rule 79. Production of Records

Records must be produced for inspection whenever required by the Superintendent, Inspector, or any officer authorized by the Postmaster General.

Rule 80. Secrecy

Every official of the Railway Mail Service is bound by the Official Secrets Act.

- (1) Information regarding the movement of mails, the contents of articles, or departmental orders must not be divulged to unauthorized persons.
 - (2) Breach of this rule entails severe disciplinary action, including dismissal.
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Chapter 7: Relations with Railway and Steamer Companies

Rule 81. Conveyance of Mails

The conveyance of mails by railway and steamer is regulated by the terms of the contracts entered into between the President of India and the carrying companies, or by the statutory rules framed under the Indian Railways Act.

- (1) The Department has the right to require the railway administration to convey mails by any train.
- (2) The accommodation provided for the mails must be to the satisfaction of the Department.

Rule 82. Weighment of Mails

For the purpose of calculating the haulage charges or other payments due to the railways, a census or weighment of mails is taken periodically.

- (1) The weighment is conducted during the **Statistical Period** (usually once a year or as agreed).
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- (2) Every bag dispatched and received during this period must be weighed, and the weight recorded in the **Weighment Statement**.
- (3) The **Head Sorting Assistant** is personally responsible for the accuracy of these records.

Rule 83. Accommodation in Trains

- (1) The Railway Administration is bound to provide suitable vans or compartments for the use of the Railway Mail Service.
- (2) The vans must be fitted with sorting cases, seats, and other necessary conveniences as per the standard specifications approved by the **Director General**.
- (3) If the accommodation provided is insufficient or defective, the matter must be reported immediately to the **Superintendent**.

Rule 84. Inspection of Mail Vans

- (1) The **Superintendent** and **Inspector** must frequently inspect the mail vans to ensure they are clean, watertight, and in good repair.
- (2) Particular attention must be paid to the lighting and locking arrangements.
- (3) Any defect must be brought to the notice of the Station Master or the Guard of the train, and a remark made in the **Daily Report**.

Rule 85. Lights and Fans

- (1) The Railway Administration is responsible for providing adequate lighting and fans in the mail vans.
- (2) If the lights fail or fans are not working, the **Head Sorting Assistant** must lodge a complaint with the electrical staff at the station and note the duration of the failure in the **Daily Report**.

Rule 86. Carriage of Dangerous Goods

- (1) No explosive, dangerous, or offensive substance shall be carried in the mail van.
- (2) If any such article is detected in the mails, it must be detained and handed over to the Railway Authorities or the Police, and a report submitted.

Rule 87. Entry into Mail Vans

- (1) No person other than the officials of the Railway Mail Service on duty is allowed to enter a mail van.
- (2) Exception: Railway officials (e.g., Guard, Ticket Examiner) may enter for the execution of their duty, provided they do not interfere with the work.
- (3) Inspecting Officers of the Department must produce their **Metal Token** or **Identity Card**.

Rule 88. Closing of Van Doors

- (1) The doors of the mail van must be kept closed and locked while the train is in motion.
- (2) They may be opened only at stations where mails are to be exchanged.
- (3) The **Mail Guard** or **Van Peon** must stand at the door when it is open to prevent unauthorized entry.

Rule 89. Railway Accidents

In case of an accident to the train:

- (1) The safety of the mails is the first consideration after the safety of life.
- (2) The staff must not leave the mails unless compelled by circumstances.

- (3) If the van is damaged, the mails must be transferred to another compartment or to a safe place under proper guard.

Rule 90. Interruptions to Mail Service

- (1) In the event of a breach of the line or other interruption, the **Superintendent** must make immediate arrangements for the transshipment of mails.
- (2) The staff must accompany the mails during transshipment and ensure their safety.

Chapter 8: Duties of Mail Peons and Van Peons

Rule 91. Duties of Van Peon

A Van Peon (now designated as MTS - Multi Tasking Staff in RMS) is attached to a section. His duties are:

- (1) To assist in the loading and unloading of mails.
- (2) To sweep and clean the mail van.
- (3) To seal bags and tie bundles under the direction of the Sorting Assistant.
- (4) To guard the door of the van at stations.

Rule 92. Duties of Mail Peon

A Mail Peon is attached to a Record Office or Mail Office. His duties are:

- (1) To convey mails between the office and the station/platform.
- (2) To clear letter boxes (if attached to the office).
- (3) To perform menial duties such as sweeping and fetching water.

Rule 93. Uniform and Badge

- (1) Every Van Peon and Mail Peon must wear the prescribed uniform and badge while on duty.
- (2) The uniform must be kept clean and tidy.

 **STATUTORY UPDATE (2025):** The 7th CPC has consolidated various Group D posts into **MTS**. While the specific functional titles like "Van Peon" may still be used operationally in the Manual, the cadre is officially **MTS**, and uniform allowances are provided annually in cash rather than physical supply in many circles.

Rule 94. Loading of Mails

- (1) The Van Peon must place the bags in the van in such a way that they can be easily taken out at the respective stations.
- (2) Heavy bags should be placed at the bottom and light bags on top.
- (3) Bags for the next station must be kept near the door.

Rule 95. Clearance of Letter Boxes

- (1) If a letter box is fixed to the mail van or located at the station, it must be cleared by the Van Peon or Mail Peon at the prescribed time.
- (2) The contents must be handed over immediately to the **Sorting Assistant**.

Rule 96. Exchange of Mails at Moving Trains

(Obsolete Rule - largely discontinued due to safety).

- *Historical Note:* Formerly, apparatus was used to catch/drop bags from moving trains. This rule is now restricted to specific guidelines prohibiting the exchange of mails while the train is in motion unless valid apparatus is provided.

Rule 97. Protection from Weather

- (1) When carrying mails between the office and the train, the Peon must protect them from rain and wet.
- (2) Tarpaulins or waterproof sheets must be used for this purpose.

Rule 98. Gratuitous Conveyance

- (1) No RMS official is allowed to carry private parcels or letters gratuitously (free of charge) in the mail van.
- (2) Any such attempt is treated as a fraud on the revenue.

Rule 99. Custody of Articles found in Van

- (1) Any article found in the mail van after the mails have been disposed of must be handed over to the **Head Sorting Assistant**.
- (2) If the owner cannot be found, it is treated as "Unclaimed Property" and sent to the **Record Office**.

Rule 100. Conduct

- (1) Van Peons and Mail Peons must be civil and obliging to the public and railway staff.
- (2) They must not loiter on the platform or converse with strangers while on duty.

Chapter 9: Sub-Record Offices (S.R.O.)

Rule 101. Sub-Record Office

A Sub-Record Office is a stationary office of the Railway Mail Service situated at the same station as a Mail Office.

- (1) It acts as the repository for the work papers of the Mail Office and the sections attached to it.
- (2) It supplies forms, bags, and stationery required for the use of the Mail Office and sections.
- (3) The official in charge is designated as the **Sub-Record Officer**.
- (4) A Sub-Record Officer may also function as a **Head Sorting Assistant**, **Sub-Sorting Assistant**, or **Mail Agent** depending on the strength of the office.

Rule 102. Duties of Sub-Record Officer

The Sub-Record Officer is responsible for:

- (1) The preparation, checking, and recording of the work papers of the sections and offices attached to his office.
- (2) The safe custody of the stock of bags, forms, and stationery.
- (3) The timely supply of these articles to the sets.
- (4) The preparation of the pay and allowance bills of the staff attached to his office (unless this duty is centralized at the Head Record Office).

 **STATUTORY UPDATE (2025):** With the implementation of **HRMS (Human Resource Management System)** and **CSI**, the preparation of pay bills is largely centralized. The SRO now primarily acts as a **Transit Point** for service requests and the physical verification of **Mail Abstracts** before digital entry.

Rule 103. Attendance at Sub-Record Office

- (1) The **Head Sorting Assistant** of every set attached to a Sub-Record Office must attend the office before the commencement of the trip or working hours.
- (2) He must sign the **Attendance Register** and receive the necessary orders, bags, and stationery for the trip.
- (3) After the completion of the trip, he must attend the office to hand over the work papers and the stock of empty bags.

Rule 104. Examination of Work Papers

- (1) The Sub-Record Officer must examine the **Daily Reports, Mail Abstracts, and Registered Abstracts** submitted by the Head Sorting Assistants.
- (2) He must check the totals of the Mail Abstracts and ensure they tally.
- (3) He must bring any irregularity or error to the notice of the **Superintendent or Inspector** immediately.

Rule 105. Forwarding of Returns

- (1) The Sub-Record Officer must forward the checked work papers to the **Head Record Office** at such intervals as may be prescribed by the **Superintendent** (usually daily or weekly).
- (2) Urgent reports regarding accidents or losses must be forwarded immediately.

Rule 106. Custody of Cash

- (1) If the Sub-Record Officer is entrusted with the payment of salary or other allowances, he is responsible for the safe custody of the cash.
- (2) The cash must be kept in a cash chest or safe embedded in the wall or floor.
- (3) The key of the safe must remain in his personal custody.

Rule 107. Absence of Sub-Record Officer

- (1) During the temporary absence of the Sub-Record Officer, his duties will be performed by the **Head Sorting Assistant** of the stationary Mail Office or by the senior-most official available.
 - (2) A note regarding the transfer of charge must be made in the **Daily Report**.
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Chapter 10: Rest Houses and Quarters

Rule 108. Rest Houses (Dormitories)

Rest Houses are provided at terminal stations and changing stations for the accommodation of the staff of Transit Sections during their halt at the out-station.

- (1) The Rest House is intended solely for the use of the staff on duty.
- (2) No family members or outsiders are permitted to occupy the Rest House.
- (3) The **Superintendent** is responsible for ensuring that the Rest House is properly furnished and maintained.

Rule 109. Rules of Occupation

- (1) The staff must maintain the Rest House in a clean and sanitary condition.
 - (2) No cooking is allowed inside the sleeping rooms.
 - (3) Gambling and the use of intoxicating drugs or liquor are strictly prohibited within the premises.
 - (4) The **Head Sorting Assistant** is responsible for the conduct of his set while in the Rest House.
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Rule 110. Inspection of Rest Houses

- (1) The **Inspector** and **Superintendent** must inspect the Rest Houses frequently.
- (2) They must check the stock of furniture and utensils against the **Inventory List**.
- (3) Any damage or loss must be recovered from the staff at fault.

Rule 111. Sorters' Quarters

Where Government quarters are provided for the residence of the RMS staff:

- (1) The allotment of quarters is made by the **Superintendent** in accordance with the rules prescribed by the **Director General**.
- (2) The occupant is responsible for the proper care of the building and fittings.

Rule 112. License Fee

- (1) Officials occupying Government quarters are liable to pay a **License Fee** (formerly Rent) as fixed by the Government.
- (2) The fee is deducted from the monthly pay of the official.
- (3) No license fee is charged for the occupation of Rest Houses by staff on tour/duty.

 **STATUTORY UPDATE (2025):** The rates of License Fee are revised periodically by the **Directorate of Estates**. As of 2025, the standard license fees for General Pool Residential Accommodation (GPRA) apply to Departmental Pool quarters unless specified otherwise.

Rule 113. Vacation of Quarters

- (1) An official must vacate the quarters immediately upon transfer, retirement, or dismissal.

- (2) Retention of quarters beyond the permissible period (usually **2 months** for transfer, **4 to 8 months** for retirement) attracts **Damage Rent** at market rates.

Rule 114. Subletting

- (1) Subletting of Government quarters, wholly or in part, is strictly prohibited.
- (2) Any official found subletting his quarters is liable to disciplinary action and cancellation of allotment.

Rule 115. Water and Electricity Charges

- (1) The occupant is liable to pay the charges for water and electricity consumed in the quarters.
- (2) In Rest Houses, these charges are borne by the Department, provided the consumption is reasonable.

Rule 116. Complaints regarding Quarters

- (1) All complaints regarding the repairs or maintenance of quarters must be addressed to the **Superintendent**.
- (2) The Superintendent will forward the requisition to the **Civil Wing** (Postal Civil Division) for necessary action.

Rule 117. Use of Rest House by Officers

- (1) Inspecting Officers (Superintendents/Inspectors) may occupy the Inspection Room in the Rest House (if provided) while on tour.
- (2) They must not occupy the beds meant for the operative staff.

Rule 118. Cleaning Allowance

- (1) A contingent allowance is sanctioned for the sweeping and cleaning of Rest Houses.

- (2) The **Sub-Record Officer** or the official in charge of the Rest House is responsible for engaging a sweeper and ensuring the work is done.

Rule 119. Furniture in Rest Houses

The standard scale of furniture for a Rest House includes:

- (1) Charpoys or Takhats (Beds).
- (2) Tables and Chairs.
- (3) Lockers for the safety of personal belongings.
- (4) Buckets and Mugs.

Rule 120. Disorderly Conduct

Any case of disorderly conduct or breach of discipline in the Rest House must be reported immediately by the Head Sorting Assistant or the Caretaker to the Superintendent.

Chapter 11: Portfolios and Equipment

Rule 121. The Portfolio

The Portfolio is a case or bag supplied to every section and set of a mail office for the safe custody of the work papers, stamps, seals, and other articles required for the trip or working hours.

- (1) It must be kept in the personal custody of the **Head Sorting Assistant**.
- (2) It must be locked when not in use.
- (3) It contains the **Guidance Book, Sorting List, Due Mail List, and the Order Book**.

Rule 122. Contents of Portfolio

The Portfolio must contain the following articles, which must be checked by the Head Sorting Assistant before the commencement of the trip:

- (1) **Date Stamps and Seals** (with ink pad and stamping ink).
- (2) **Check Slips** (Pink and Blue).
- (3) **Labels** for bags.
- (4) **Sealing Wax and Twine**.
- (5) **Knife, Scissors, and Needles**.
- (6) **Error Book and Daily Report** forms.
- (7) **Carbon Paper and Spare Forms**.

Rule 123. Inspection of Portfolio

- (1) The **Record Officer** or **Sub-Record Officer** must inspect the portfolios periodically (at least once a month).
- (2) He must ensure that the contents are complete and in good condition.
- (3) Damaged articles must be replaced immediately.

Rule 124. Care of Seals and Stamps

- (1) The Date Stamps and Seals are the most important articles in the portfolio.
- (2) They must be cleaned daily.
- (3) When not in use, they must be kept locked in the portfolio to prevent misuse.
- (4) If a seal or stamp is lost, the matter must be reported immediately by **telegram/phone** to the **Superintendent**, and a "Loss of Stamp" report submitted.

Rule 125. Guidance Book

Every section and mail office is supplied with a Guidance Book.

- (1) It contains the orders and instructions issued by the **Superintendent** regarding the disposal of irregular mails, changes in sorting lists, and other temporary arrangements.
- (2) The **Head Sorting Assistant** must read the Guidance Book before starting work and initial the entries.

Rule 126. Order Book

- (1) The Order Book contains the permanent orders issued by the **Superintendent** and **Inspector**.
- (2) Every official attached to the set must read and sign the Order Book in token of having understood the orders.
- (3) It is a permanent record and must be preserved carefully.

Chapter 12: Stationery and Forms

Rule 127. Supply of Stationery

- (1) The **Record Officer** is responsible for the supply of stationery and forms to the sections and offices attached to his record office.
- (2) The supply is made on a **Monthly** or **Quarterly** basis, based on the average consumption.
- (3) Economy must be exercised in the use of stationery.

Rule 128. Indents

- (1) The **Head Sorting Assistant** must submit an indent for the required stationery to the **Record Officer** on the prescribed date.
- (2) The indent must be scrutinized by the Record Officer before compliance.

Rule 129. Waste Paper

- (1) All waste paper, old forms, and sweepings of the mail van/office must be collected and sacked.
- (2) They must be made over to the **Record Office** for disposal (sale as waste paper).
- (3) Under no circumstances should waste paper be thrown out of the train or burnt (unless classified as secret/confidential).

Chapter 13: Miscellaneous Provisions**Rule 130. Trial Cards**

- (1) **Trial Cards** are service postcards dropped into letter boxes or posted at offices to test the speed and regularity of the mail service.
- (2) They contain instructions to the handling officials to stamp the date and hour of receipt and dispatch.
- (3) Any official receiving a Trial Card must carefully follow the instructions printed on it and forward it by the first mail.
- (4) Detention of a Trial Card is a serious irregularity.

Rule 131. Metal Tokens (Detailed)

- (1) The Metal Token carried by RMS officials is the property of the Government.

- (2) It must be surrendered when the official proceeds on leave for more than **4 months**, or when he quits the service.
- (3) **Loss of Token:** If a token is lost, the official is liable to pay the cost of replacement (currently fixed at **Rs. 50 to Rs. 100** depending on the Circle/Type).

Rule 132. Traveling Allowance (T.A.) Bills

- (1) The T.A. Bills of the traveling staff (Sorting Assistants, Mail Guards, Van Peons) are prepared by the **Record Officer** or **Sub-Record Officer** on the basis of the **Daily Reports**.
- (2) The bills are checked and countersigned by the **Superintendent** or **Assistant Superintendent** before payment.
- (3) False claims of T.A. are punishable with dismissal.

Rule 133. Overtime Allowance (OTA)

- (1) Staff performing duty beyond the prescribed working hours are entitled to Overtime Allowance.
- (2) The claim must be supported by the **Daily Report** showing the actual hours of duty performed.
- (3) The rates of OTA are fixed by the **Director General**.

🔔 **STATUTORY UPDATE (2025):** OTA is strictly regulated. For operative staff in RMS, the hourly rate is calculated based on the formula: **(Pay + DA) / 200** (approximate, subject to specific 7th CPC orders).

Rule 134. Urgent Calls

- (1) Every RMS official is liable to be called for duty at any time in case of emergency (e.g., sudden illness of staff, accidents).
- (2) Refusal to attend such a call is treated as "Disobedience of Orders".

Rule 135. Definition of Terms (Summary)

- **Sorting Case:** The pigeon-hole cupboard used for sorting letters.
- **Label Holder:** The metal or plastic fixture on a bag to hold the label.
- **Sealing Wax:** The material used for impressing the seal on the bag (now largely replaced by **Plastic Seals** or **Lead Seals**).
- **Twine:** The string used for tying bundles and bags.

Appendix: Key Forms Used in RMS

Form No.	Name of Form	Purpose
M-1	Daily Report	Report of the set's trip/work.
M-2	Mail Abstract	Account of bags received/dispatched.
M-3	Registered Abstract	Account of registered articles.
M-6	Due Mail List	List of bags due to be exchanged.
M-7	Sorting List	Instructions for sorting.
M-20	Bag Balance Report	Account of empty bags.
M-53	Error Book	Record of irregularities.
Ms-8	Check Slip	Label for bundles (Pink/Blue).